There was not much of a honeymoon. I got back to work two days after the wedding.

Meena is an orthodox Indian Hindu wife. Her daily outings were to temples, and she had a fixed weekly schedule: Srikanteswaram on Monday, Attukal Devi Temple on Tuesday and Friday, Srivaraham Temple on Thursday and Sri Padmanabha Swami Temple on Saturday. When we had children, we would go to the movies, once in a couple of months, the four of us on my scooter.

I would take her on tours to Indian cities once in a while. Her first travel abroad was to France when I led the ISRO team to Vernon for the Viking-Vikas joint venture in September 1974. We had gone to France with both our children, but having found good education in English medium hard to come by in Vernon, we send back our son Sankar to India in 1975 (Kalam was kind enough to take him back during one of his visits) and daughter Geetha the next year when my wife went on a six-months break to India. Our children started schooling in Trivandrum, staying with my elder sister till we returned in 1978.

Meena had a wonderful time in Veron, the women of our fifty-plus scientists forming a virtual commune in the French town of St Marcel. She also mingled with the local residents and vendors who came to sell their wares, picking up smatterings of French.

On weekends we drove to Paris and other parts of France in an 800cc Fiat car that I had bought secondhand for 500 Francs. My successor Chandran inherited this antique piece of automobile when I returned to India in early 1978, leaving the team to complete the work. During the yearly vacations we travelled across Europe.

One of the things she could never stand was alcohol. I kept telling her that wine was to the French what water was to us Indians, but she would just not give up her stand against the spirit. She knew we men had a few drinks at the parties, and she did not make an issue out of it till I kept her out of drinking.

Once, during an Aerospace exhibition, we as a couple were invited to inaugurate a pavilion. While fine French wine was being passed around, I